What the evidence supports

Public evidence brief • City of San Diego • 12 October 2026

The strongest defensible argument is for a measurable shift toward housing and eligible civilian response, tighter police overtime controls, and an independent reconciliation of property-disposal records. There is real evidence for those demands. There is not yet proof that police spending alone causes homelessness, that all police involvement is harmful, or that SDPD systematically destroyed property unlawfully.

Three records matter most: the City Auditor's overtime findings; the encampment audit's shelter-referral and placement figures; and NextRequest's released ESD impound logs, which contain identifiable short-hold disposal entries and contradictions. These connect public spending, access to shelter and the treatment of people's possessions to concrete questions the City can answer.

Use the presentation for the public briefing, the incident table for the property inquiry, and the linked original documents to check each assertion. The policy options below are recommendations, not findings that a particular cut will pay for a particular housing program.

S02 — OCA 24-08: Police overtime

S01 — OCA-26-07: Response to homeless encampments

NR25010772 — ESD Impound Log FY18-23

NR36242342 — ESD Abatement Impound Log 2022-07-01 to 2023-10-04

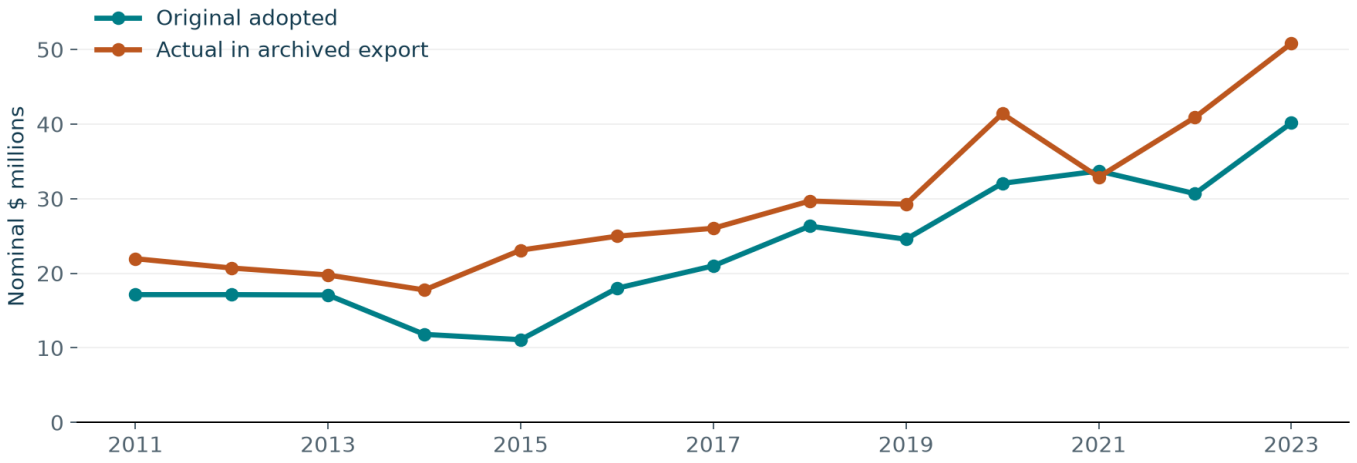
Police spending: separate the budget problem from the accusation

FY2027 adopted Police General Fund spending is $718,299,548, up $14,784,070 from FY2026's $703,515,478. The Police all-funds total is $725,600,266; it must not be substituted for the General Fund figure. FY2025 General Fund actual spending was $691,169,483 against an original adopted $673,002,146: a $18,167,337 difference, before considering later appropriations or reimbursements. [S08 PDF p.7; S03 PDF p.2.]

The reproducible historical test is narrower: overtime actuals exceeded original adopted overtime in 12 of 13 fiscal years in the archived FY2011–FY2023 exports. FY2023's difference is $10,656,234, or 26.5%. The full Police department difference that year was $4,200,000, demonstrating why overtime and total-department variances cannot be added. [DATA-BUDGET; DATA-ACTUAL.]

The 2024 audit found weak limits on overtime hours and recommended controls and consideration of civilian staffing. It also identified staffing pressures and comparatively lower overtime shares than peer departments. More recently, the City's FY2026 midyear statement projected non-cost-recoverable overtime on budget; that is a projection, not a final audited actual. [S02 PDF pp.3–4; S05.]

Conclusion: repeated original-budget overruns justify a variance review and enforceable controls. They do not establish fraud, unauthorized spending, or that one department caused the entire City deficit. Salary agreements, Council appropriations, revenue and reimbursable assignments also matter.



S08 — FY2027 adopted Police budget

S03 — IBA 26-09: Police FY2026 budget analysis

S02 — OCA 24-08: Police overtime

S05 — City statement: FY2026 midyear overtime projection

DATA-BUDGET — City operating budget export, archived 2026-10-07

DATA-ACTUAL — City operating actuals export, archived 2026-10-07; partial archive

A concrete budget line for an alternatives review

The Independent Budget Analyst identifies $28,652,346 and 89 FTEs for Neighborhood Policing in FY2026. Its components are $20,860,747 for Neighborhood Policing Teams, $5,957,436 for the Homeless Outreach Team, and $1,834,163 for management. This is an identifiable review population, not a demonstrated amount available to cut. [S03 PDF p.59 / A-44.]

The $3,276,002 Neighborhood Policing overtime category plus $2,390,489 Clean SD overtime equals $5,666,491. Both are already inside the spending above and inside the department's overtime total. IBA associates the first with Seized Assets funding and the second with General Fund. NPT's total overtime is larger ($6,329,243), so the two designated categories are not all NPT overtime. [S03 PDF pp.5–7,60.]

Review Clean SD's $2.39 million police overtime allocation first as a defined service: identify hours spent on safety, arrests, transport, outreach and waiting; price civilian coverage for eligible duties; preserve a response for credible threats; and determine the actual marginal cost avoided. Shifting an officer's assignment without reducing paid hours does not create cash savings.

A transfer proposal should state which services and positions change, funding restrictions, labor and transition costs, who takes over each duty, and the outcomes purchased. HOT includes service partnerships and is described as generally non-enforcement, so its whole budget cannot reasonably be labeled punitive spending. [S03 PDF p.61.]

S03 — IBA 26-09: Police FY2026 budget analysis

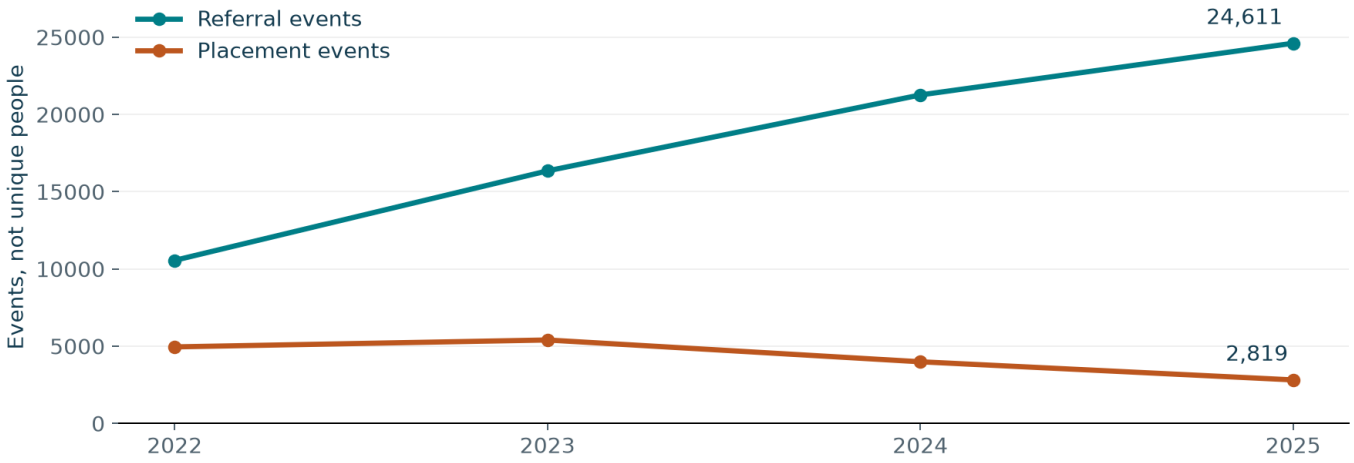
Housing access is the outcome test

In the audit's shelter series, placements declined from 5,403 in FY2023 to 2,819 in FY2025. FY2025 recorded 24,611 referrals. These are referral and placement events, not unique people or a cohort success rate; repeated requests and improved recording prevent that interpretation. [S01 PDF p.31 / printed p.26, Exhibit 10.]

The audit found that HUD-defined unsheltered homelessness had not fallen citywide over its post-ordinance comparison, although fewer people were counted in public areas. Safe sleeping counts as unsheltered under that definition. Enforcement contacts increased, but the audit could not establish individuals' geographic movement. [S01 PDF pp.17–20,32–36.]

The responsible inference is a service-capacity and measurement problem: citations, encampment closures and referrals cannot substitute for verified access to suitable shelter and durable housing. These descriptive data do not prove that enforcement caused the placement decline or that increasing police funding caused homelessness.

Measure the same eligible population across response models: accepted and completed placements; housing retention at 90 and 180 days; repeat displacement; property loss; injuries; and fully allocated cost. Compare like cases over the same period, with referral eligibility and unmet need visible. Avoid publishing personal or medical identifiers.



S01 — OCA-26-07: Response to homeless encampments

Property records: a real investigative lead

NextRequest request 23-3164 released ESD's 30-page FY18–23 impound log. An automated screen retained 716 rows with a nonempty impound-date cell and found 27 marked DISPOSED with a parseable action date fewer than 90 calendar days later. Five rows lacking an impound date were excluded, and malformed or negative dates were kept separately. [NR25010772; impound-log-screen.csv.]

The strongest examples are recurring, dated entries rather than a single typo. Case 3356753 has two rows showing March 5 to May 23, 2018 (79 days); case 3364404 shows March 12 to May 23 (72 days); case 3367112 shows March 19 to May 23 (65 days). Case 3179697 shows December 20, 2020 to March 4, 2021 (74 days). The dates and DISPOSED labels were checked against the PDF images. [NR25010772 PDF pp.4,27.]

The 2022 City Attorney summary describes 90-day storage in its account of the 2011 Isaiah settlement. The released August 2023 ESD SOP expressly requires at least 90 days before disposal. The historical summary is not a substitute for the complete settlement and policy versions applicable to each older incident. [S11 PDF p.2; NR37418617 PDF p.9, section 3.5.6.]

This establishes discrepancies deserving an explanation, not 27 adjudicated violations. Three candidates have explicit conflicting evidence; other rows may contain clerical errors or different item histories. These are ESD records. A claim against SDPD requires proof of its custody or conduct in the specific event.

NR25010772 — ESD Impound Log FY18-23

S11 — City Attorney 2022 homelessness litigation status memorandum

NR37418617 — ESD Encampment Abatement Procedures 2023-08-08

Incident exhibit: dates the City should reconcile

The table reports what the released log says. Calendar-day intervals are independently calculated. A case can contain multiple items or rows; counts are not counts of affected people. Original table-row locators, including headers, appear in the CSV.

Case / locator	Impounded	Recorded disposal	Days
3356753 • p.4, rows 2–3	2018-03-05	2018-05-23	79
3364404 • p.4, row 6	2018-03-12	2018-05-23	72
3367112 • p.4, row 7	2018-03-19	2018-05-23	65
3179697 • p.27, row 40	2020-12-20	2021-03-04	74

Two FY2023 cases, 3864885 and 4110177, show intervals of 0 and 5 days but contain notes saying items were removed after 90 days. Both appear again in the overlapping 2024 release. They are contradictory records, not confirmed short holds. [NR25010772 PDF p.30; NR36242342 PDF p.1.]

Case 3146448 shows a 17-day interval on page 26 but a different disposal date and item description for the same case and impound date on page 27. Do not present the 17-day value as an established event. Case 4311867 in NR36242342 p.2 shows a same-day DISPOSED action without an explanatory disposal note; the actual event date is unresolved.

The newer Salesforce release, NR36242343, contains 12 rows and four dated disposals; all four intervals are at least 90 days. One row remains STORED despite a partial-return note. That illustrates why a status field alone cannot establish what happened to every item.

NR25010772 — ESD Impound Log FY18-23

NR36242342 — ESD Abatement Impound Log 2022-07-01 to 2023-10-04

NR36242343 — ESD Abatement Impound Logs 2023-10-01 to release

Test the correct policy against the correct event

An ESD abatement and an SDPD enforcement operation have different property rules. The August 2023 SOP separates the teams and operations. For an arrested person, property goes to SDPD under its procedures; ESD support teams do not simply apply the abatement-storage workflow. [NR37418617 PDF p.10, sections 4.1–4.4.]

For ESD abatements, the released SOP specifies a normal minimum 24-hour notice; a new notice if the delay exceeds 48 hours; documented approval and qualifying conditions for expedited three-hour action; photos; eligibility decisions; impound logs; and 90-day storage. Certain identification and medications are transferred to SDPD. [NR37418617 PDF pp.5–9.]

The 2019 NPD manual characterizes SDPD's ESD-abatement role as peacekeeping, services and safety. That describes an assigned role, not proof that the role was followed at a particular scene. An older manual cannot establish current procedures without checking amendments. [S12 PDF p.32.]

For each disputed event, join the notice and its timestamp, operation type, exception approval, photos, item eligibility decisions, ESD-to-SDPD transfer receipt, chain of custody, storage entry, retrieval requests and disposal authorization. Missing public records do not by themselves prove a breach; contradictions should be put to the responsible custodian.

NR37418617 — ESD Encampment Abatement Procedures 2023-08-08

S12 — SDPD Neighborhood Policing Operations Manual 2019 (redacted)

A civilian alternative should be specific and measurable

San Diego County already provides Mobile Crisis Response Teams consisting of a clinician, case manager and peer specialist. Its published scope excludes threats of violence and medical emergencies. The operational question is which City calls qualify, whether teams are available, and what happens when a call escalates. [S14, service model and dispatch FAQs.]

Dee and Pyne's preregistered Denver STAR study used a quasi-experimental design and found 34% fewer reports of targeted lower-level offenses during the pilot, without a detectable change in more serious offenses. Part of the effect reflected less criminal labeling. This is relevant evidence for eligible civilian crisis response, not proof of reduced homelessness in San Diego or a forecast of local savings. [S13 PDF pp.1–3,6–7.]

A practical reform option is a funded civilian response pilot for defined nonviolent calls, linked to housing navigation and accessible property retrieval, with clear emergency escalation. Publish eligibility, accepted calls, response times, unresolved demand, adverse events, placement completion, housing retention and costs for both the pilot and a comparable baseline.

Choose any reallocation amount only after identifying unrestricted, avoidable Police costs and the replacement capacity those dollars purchase. No defensible dollar-for-dollar savings figure has yet been established by this investigation.

S14 — County of San Diego Mobile Crisis Response Teams

S13 — Dee and Pyne (2022): Denver STAR quasi-experimental evaluation

Evidence that complicates the argument

The April 2026 encampment audit was generally favorable about storage practices and coordination. It recommended periodic review of excluded items and improved language access. Those findings must accompany the historical log discrepancies, not be hidden. The historical cases and the audit's more recent operational scope are not interchangeable. Implementation of the May 2026 recommendation targets was not verified here. [S01 PDF pp.48–54.]

Public-area homelessness and response times improved in the audit's comparisons. Police overtime pressures include staffing, negotiated compensation and reimbursable work. The FY2026 midyear projection reported improved control. None excuses a proven violation, but each matters to an honest allocation argument. [S01 PDF pp.4,19; S02 PDF pp.3–4; S05.]

FY2027 HSSD departmental spending is $61,988,102, compared with $53,821,132 in FY2026. This is not the City's entire homelessness budget; transfers and replacement funding affect the change. It prevents a simple claim that the named department's budget was cut while Police grew. It does not establish that housing need is adequately funded. [S09 PDF p.5.]

the records support targeted budget scrutiny, a civilian-response alternative and an independent property-record audit. They do not yet establish universal police culpability, illegal budgeting, or a causal estimate linking Police appropriations to homelessness.

S01 — OCA-26-07: Response to homeless encampments

S02 — OCA 24-08: Police overtime

S05 — City statement: FY2026 midyear overtime projection

S09 — FY2027 adopted Homelessness Strategies and Solutions budget

NextRequest search and access record

Eight public search terms produced 2,124 unique published requests: abatement, encampment, homeless property, property storage, homeless belongings, Neighborhood Policing, overtime and 6.18. The last was exploratory; it did not establish a relevant policy identifier. The property-storage search was capped at 1,200 of 1,491 results; other searches were read to their reported ends.

Document listings were examined for 36 selected requests, exposing 152 public document records before the service returned HTTP 429. The investigation then concentrated on six acquired PDFs from three directly relevant requests: 23-3164, 24-4229 and 24-5629. This was a targeted search, not a complete inspection of every document in every request.

Request 26-772 also lists an existing spreadsheet, “Copy of Abatements Completed 7.31.23 to 1.28.26.xlsx” (document 58632019). Its public metadata was found, but the download returned 403 and no embedded public viewer was available. Its contents were not analyzed. Other PDFs were acquired through their public document pages’ embedded viewers.

The original logs contain personal information. The shareable package includes anonymized analytic rows and links to those originals; it does not republish raw requester text or the unredacted logs. Locally preserved source files retain provenance and SHA-256 hashes. No request, comment or message was submitted.

Request	Existing public records	Status
23-3164	FY18–23 ESD impound log • document 25010772	Acquired / screened
24-4229	2022–2024 logs • documents 36242342, 36242343	Acquired / screened
24-5629	ESD SOP and notices • documents 37418616–18	Acquired / read
26-772	Abatements spreadsheet • document 58632019	Metadata only / 403

NR25010772 — ESD Impound Log FY18-23

NR36242342 — ESD Abatement Impound Log 2022-07-01 to 2023-10-04

NR36242343 — ESD Abatement Impound Logs 2023-10-01 to release

NR37418617 — ESD Encampment Abatement Procedures 2023-08-08

Records needed to turn leads into findings

Property priority: obtain existing item-level records and revision histories for the exhibit cases, original impound notices, disposal authorizations, retrieval contacts and applicable policy/settlement versions. Request the exact same-case discrepancy for 3146448 and notes/date contradictions for 3864885 and 4110177. Ask ESD to identify the actual destruction date for 4311867. An unsent request draft is included.

Enforcement priority: obtain current SDPD property procedures and event records tying arrests, available/appropriate shelter offers, progressive-enforcement history and property custody to the same event. Compare abatement and enforcement operations separately. Seek existing audit workpapers and the records documenting implementation of the two 2026 property-access recommendations, subject to applicable disclosure rules.

Budget priority: obtain FY2024–FY2026 final overtime actuals, original and revised appropriations, transfers, reimbursements actually collected, authorization records and task-level NPD/Clean SD hours. Require a reconciliation before treating an overrun as avoidable or unauthorized.

Outcome priority: seek existing de-identified data linking referrals to completed placements and housing retention, with eligibility and denominators. Obtain civilian-response capacity and cost records for comparable calls. This would allow a stronger evaluation than juxtaposing a budget total with a homelessness count.

Methods and limits

Financial analysis used the City operating-budget and actuals exports archived October 7, 2026. SHA-256 hashes were checked. Exact-decimal General Fund expense aggregates from original CSV files matched their Parquet equivalents. Adopted budget rows were selected explicitly; proposed and blank-cycle rows were excluded. Overtime uses budget account 500128 versus actual accounts 500123, 500124 and 500133. The actuals archive is marked partial and ends FY2023; the separate FY2027 budget PDF supplies FY2025 actuals and later adopted totals. Dollars are nominal.

Property analysis extracted three released PDF tables with PyMuPDF, kept source/page/row locators, excluded six displayed training-example rows, and screened nonnegative disposal intervals below 90 days. Eight real rows on NR36242342 page 2 required manual transcription because merged table geometry lost their dates; the transcription was checked visually and against page text. Twenty-seven older candidates were visually checked on the relevant pages. Five older rows without an impound-date value were excluded; invalid and negative dates remain separate flags.

Overlapping releases are not pooled into a violation rate. The 716 older screened rows are not a census of all abatements, stored items or people. A log cannot reveal property immediately discarded without impoundment, and an apparent-date discrepancy is not proof of a policy violation. The applicable historical rules, item-level events and responsible agency require confirmation.

Every substantive source is linked in the source index. analysis/findings.json records supported, mixed and unproven claims. The companion workbook and scripts preserve calculations and qualifications. The PDF briefing is generated from the same slide content as the editable PowerPoint; PowerPoint rendering itself was not independently executed in this environment.

DATA-BUDGET — City operating budget export, archived 2026-10-07

DATA-ACTUAL — City operating actuals export, archived 2026-10-07; partial archive

Source index and preserved evidence

Page references throughout are PDF pages unless a printed page is also given. Links lead to original public records. Original file hashes are preserved in source-manifest.json.

DATA-ACTUAL — City operating actuals export, archived 2026-10-07; partial archive

https://seshat.datasd.org/operating_actuals/actuals_operating_datasd.csv

DATA-BUDGET — City operating budget export, archived 2026-10-07

https://seshat.datasd.org/operating_budget/budget_operating_datasd.csv

NR25010772 — ESD Impound Log FY18-23

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/25010772

NR36242342 — ESD Abatement Impound Log 2022-07-01 to 2023-10-04

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/36242342

NR36242343 — ESD Abatement Impound Logs 2023-10-01 to release

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/36242343

NR37418616 — ESD 24 Hour Posting Notice 2023-08-03

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/37418616

NR37418617 — ESD Encampment Abatement Procedures 2023-08-08

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/37418617

NR37418618 — ESD Impounded Property Notice 2023-08-03

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/documents/37418618

NR58632019 — Abatements completed 2023-07-31 to 2026-01-28: metadata only, contents not acquired

https://sandiego.nextrequest.com/requests/26-772

S01 — OCA-26-07: Response to homeless encampments

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2026-04/performance-audit-of-the-city-s-response-to-homeless-encampments-since-the-unsafe-camping-ordinance.pdf

S02 — OCA 24-08: Police overtime

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2024-02/24-08_performance_audit_sdpd_ot.pdf

S03 — IBA 26-09: Police FY2026 budget analysis

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2026-03/26-09-analysis-of-the-police-department-s-fiscal-year-2026-budget.pdf

S04 — City encampment cleanup and abatement procedures, current webpage

https://www.sandiego.gov/homelessness-strategies-and-solutions/services/abatement

S05 — City statement: FY2026 midyear overtime projection

https://www.insidesandiego.org/san-diego-police-department-brings-overtime-budget-mid-year-report

S06 — State Auditor 2023-102.2

https://www.auditor.ca.gov/reports/2023-102-2/

S07 — Police overtime reporting internal orders, March 2025 release

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2025-03/tb-25-01-updated-internal-orders-for-overtime-reporting-redacted.pdf

S08 — FY2027 adopted Police budget

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2026-08/fy27ab_v2police.pdf

S09 — FY2027 adopted Homelessness Strategies and Solutions budget

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/2026-08/fy27ab_v2hssd.pdf

S10 — Unsafe camping ordinance as adopted 2023

https://docs.sandiego.gov/council_reso_ordinance/rao2023/O-21674.pdf

S11 — City Attorney 2022 homelessness litigation status memorandum

https://docs.sandiego.gov/memooflaw/MS-2022-6.pdf

S12 — SDPD Neighborhood Policing Operations Manual 2019 (redacted)

https://www.sandiego.gov/sites/default/files/neighborhood_policing_operations_manual_2019_redacted.pdf

S13 — Dee and Pyne (2022): Denver STAR quasi-experimental evaluation

https://tom-dee.github.io/files/sciadv.abm2106.pdf

S14 — County of San Diego Mobile Crisis Response Teams

https://www.sandiegocounty.gov/mcrt/